

Induction of labor

Your baby is described as being overdue if you have not gone into labor by the time you are 40 weeks pregnant. This is not unusual since most women do not go into labor at exactly 40 weeks, and anything between 37 and 41 weeks is considered to be normal.

As the exact mechanism that initiates labor is unknown, it's not clear why some women don't go into labor on their own and go past their due date.

What will be done

After 41 weeks, there is an increased risk of stillbirth, and even more so after 42 weeks. Most doctors recommend inducing labor by 41 weeks to avoid the risks of late pregnancy. This involves softening, shortening, and dilating the cervix by either inserting a balloon into the cervix or a prostaglandin pessary into the vagina. This first part of the process can take up to 24 hours. Once the cervix has opened slightly, the next part involves breaking the waters and using an oxytocin drip to start contractions. On average, it will be another 12 hours before baby is born.

Being induced increases the chance of having an epidural and an assisted birth. While it may sound long and complicated, induction is a gradual and safe process and important to consider if there is a risk to the health of the baby.

Stripping the membranes After 40 weeks, your doctor may do an internal examination. They'll insert a gloved finger into the cervix and pull the membranes in a circular pattern. This can soften the cervix and increase the chance of you going into labor by 30 percent in the next 48 hours. It's safe for you and your baby but can cause cramps and slight bleeding.

Assessments after 42 weeks Many doctors induce labor by 41 or 42 weeks. If your pregnancy goes beyond 42 weeks and you don't want to be induced, your doctor may offer monitoring with scans to measure the baby's pulse and volume of fluid around the baby and you may have an NST (see p.418) once or twice a week until labor to pick up any signs that the placenta is failing. If a problem is found, you'll be advised to have a Cesarean or an induction of labor.

If you decide to go past 42 weeks, it is very important to immediately seek help if your baby's pattern of movements change.

How you're feeling

Although it can be stressful, going past your due date does not significantly increase your health risks. You may be worried, that your baby will grow too large, but they'll unlikely put on enough weight in the last week or so to make a big difference, and most overdue babies have a normal birth weight.